

## Chapter 102-2 - Courtship

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Jiuying held up her orchid fingers<sup>1</sup> to arrange her hair, then lifted her foot to step the feather into the weeds, swaying her figure as she walked away.

Ning Fuyi nodded as if understanding, lowering her head to look at the parrot standing sadly beside the feather. The corners of her mouth twitched, then she instructed Hannya.

"You and Xique<sup>2</sup> protect Su Mo well. If there's even the slightest abnormality, inform me immediately."

Seeing Hannya nod seriously, Ning Fuyi finally felt at ease. Her robes fluttered as she transformed into flowing light, disappearing under the pale dawn.

Although this matter was related to Penglai, she and Jiuying didn't head toward Penglai's direction, but instead went to Yichan Sea<sup>3</sup> beyond the Six Realms.

Yichan Sea was a sea left behind when heaven and earth were first created, located south of the South Sea. This place had no spiritual energy or heavenly light, no grass or trees grew, and any immortal, demon, spirit, or ghost who arrived here would be like a bird entering water - helpless.

Because of these characteristics, this place had once served as the most impregnable prison of the Divine Realm, imprisoning many fallen gods and fallen immortals. Later, as the Divine Realm fell, Yichan Sea sank again and had been forgotten for tens of millions of years.

Ning Fuyi conjured a large umbrella to resist the overwhelming sandstorm, stepping on scattered bones as she walked toward the waves.

"Penglai really has some nerve, actually daring to establish a prison in this place. Do they really think they're the Divine Clan?" Jiuying crouched behind Ning Fuyi, spitting out sand from her mouth while shouting over the wind, "Are you sure we need to go down into this Yichan Sea?"

Ning Fuyi didn't speak, only made a gesture to confirm, then struggled to stand firm under a giant rock standing in the sandstorm. She raised her hand to put away the large umbrella, causing sandstorm and icy seawater to fly straight at their faces - even the giant rock couldn't block it.

"This damned Penglai Right Envoy<sup>4</sup> has followed Emperor Tianrui<sup>5</sup> for thousands of years and is an extremely upright and incorruptible person. How easy could it be for us to turn him to our side?" Jiuying pressed her back firmly against the giant rock, fear rising in her heart as she listened to the deafening sound of waves.

After all, this was a place that once imprisoned fallen gods - it could intimidate even gods.

"He was upright and incorruptible before imprisonment. I don't believe that after being imprisoned here by Penglai for over two thousand years, he could still be very upright." Ning Fuyi sneered as she found a stone larger than her head on the ground, conjured ropes to wrap around it, then tied the other end around her own waist.

"Hey, what are you doing..." Jiuying turned to flee but was grabbed by Ning Fuyi and held tightly.

Then without a moment's hesitation, she held the giant stone in one hand and pulled Jiuying with the other, leaping up in the sandstorm.

Immediately, seawater half as tall as the sky splashed up. The two of them entered the sea in the blink of an eye. The moment they entered the water, it was like ice needles piercing their bones, immediately forming a layer of frost around their bodies.

Yichan Sea could wash away all disguises and immortal arts. Ning Fuyi's appearance, changed for many years, returned to its original form in the sea. Her pupils returned to normal, her high brow bone lowered, her blade-like features gradually softened, with only the shape of her phoenix eyes unchanged.

The stone pulled them rapidly down. Before they could freeze into frost, they fell out of the seawater and crashed heavily into a dried coral forest.

After leaving the seawater, the frost on their bodies finally melted. Jiuying spat out a mouthful of seawater and dry-heaved for a moment in the dry sand before remembering Ning Fuyi, pulling her out of the coral forest.

"Worthy of the legendary Yichan Sea. After such a washing, even the dregs in my bone cracks are clean." Jiuying stood up shivering, looking around.

Below was no different from the seabed, with sand and reefs everywhere, everything appearing dried and withered. Many fish bones and dehydrated dried fish lay on the ground. The sand had accumulated thickly, and the heavy fishy smell was nauseating.

Above was the tranquil Yichan Sea, containing only seawater with not half a swimming fish visible.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes and shivered for a while before silently standing up, evaporating the salt water from her body, and taking out two masks from her Thought Pearl<sup>6</sup>.

In the seawater of Yichan Sea, no power could be used. Fortunately, she and Jiuying had taken water-avoiding pills beforehand, or they would have suffered even more than now.

This desolate seabed had no living beings and no spiritual energy. Apart from the immortal power within their bodies, they couldn't cultivate, and when circulating their power, they couldn't feel the surrounding qi flow.

In one word: withered.

The underwater prison wasn't hard to find - they just needed to head toward the only place with living aura.

"Who goes there..."

They had just seen a rock wall towering into the seawater when they heard an angry shout, but this shout was cut off halfway. A celestial general in silver-white armor fell at their feet.

Ning Fuyi lifted her foot and looked at another celestial general who was half-kneeling toward her.

"Hall Master." That celestial general's voice was hoarse and shrill. "This place has been arranged. The Penglai Right Envoy is right here."

"Good, you don't need to follow." The voice-changed Ning Fuyi spoke, then walked with Jiuying into the cave under the rock wall. The cave was pitch black, with the dim light of the seabed outside.

Walking through the cave, Ning Fuyi looked up to see a long string of stone steps beneath her feet. The steps were stacked high, one by one, finally stopping in mid-air several zhang<sup>7</sup> high.

Several chains formed from ice water hung down from the sea, all piercing through one person's body at their ends - wrists, waist, all locked with icy water chains. Spots of blood had frozen into ice, layer upon layer attached to the skin.

Seaweed-like curled long hair hung down to the ground. The limbs had firm flesh and bone but were pale without blood color, looking no different from a corpse. Two pieces of scale-like cloth wrapped around the chest and waist as covering.

The eyebrows were delicate, the lips thin and pale.

"Is this a man or woman? Why can't I tell?" Jiuying leaned close to Ning Fuyi's ear and asked. "If you say it's a woman, there's nothing there. If you say it's a man... there's still nothing there."

"Neither man nor woman." Ning Fuyi stood unmoved like a mountain, her phoenix eyes gleaming under the mask. "It's a merperson<sup>8</sup>."

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## Footnotes:

1. **Orchid fingers (兰花指)** - A delicate hand gesture where fingers are positioned like orchid petals, often associated with feminine grace in Chinese culture.
2. **Xique (喜鹊)** - Literally "magpie," one of Ning Fuyi's demon servants who has taken human form.
3. **Yichan Sea (一阐海)** - A primordial sea that exists beyond the normal realms, possessing the power to strip away all magical abilities and disguises.
4. **Penglai Right Envoy (蓬莱右使)** - A high-ranking official in the Penglai hierarchy, traditionally known for uprightness and loyalty.
5. **Emperor Tianrui (天瑞帝君)** - The ruler of Penglai, whom the Right Envoy has served faithfully for millennia.
6. **Thought Pearl (一念珠)** - A magical storage device that can hold items in a dimensional space.
7. **Zhang (丈)** - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.3 meters or 10.8 feet.
8. **Merperson (鲛人)** - In Chinese mythology, merpeople are often genderless or can change gender, which explains why the imprisoned figure appears to have characteristics of neither man nor woman.